Language & Cognition: Intro to psycholinguistics WiSe 2026–2027

Syllabus

Dr. Deniz Özyıldız (he/they)

---

1. Class hours

I am teaching three iterations of this class this semester:

when		*where*
Monday (A)	14:00–15:30	17.25
Tuesday (B)	11:30–13:00	17.71
Tuesday (E)	14:00–15:30	11.62

These will roughly be the same in content and I don't mind if you come to a different session than the one you are enrolled for (e.g., if you're enrolled for Monday, and, for whatever reason, skip Monday and show up Tuesday afternoon).

2. Contact information

You may contact me whenever through the following channels:

email	`deniz.ozyildiz@ling.uni-stuttgart.de`
webex	`https://unistuttgart.webex.com/meet/deniz.ozyildiz`
office	Kepler 17, 4.050
office hours	by appointment, online or irl

I will generally be very happy to hear from you or to make time to just chat.

Informal forms of address are fine ('Dear Deniz, . . . ') and you may even (carefully) *duz* me. If you feel more comfortable using more polite forms, that's okay too. With this, just bear in mind that other people's preferences will surely vary.

If you're going to be absent, that's okay. You can send me an email letting me know, but you do not need to do so. As far as I'm concerned, doctor's notes etc. are not necessary.

English is the easiest language for our common purposes, but if you would like to communicate with me in, e.g., German, because that's easier or faster for you, please do so.

3. Course description

This course is an introduction to psycholinguistics, the scientific study of what happens in our bodies and minds when we produce and perceive language. The field is at the intersection of psychology and linguistics. It borrows, e.g., experimental methods from the former and draws on our understanding of language provided by the latter (representations of sounds, syntactic structure, etc.)

Psycholinguistic methods can be used to study first languages, subsequent languages, language in adults, language in infants and children, people with varieties of 'disorders', and so on. It isn't

constrained to any single component of language, but can be used to study how we represent words, single sounds, syntactic structure, the meanings of sentences, and so on.

We will focus on **first language acquisition**, **perception** and **production**, and start by asking questions like:

- What (if anything) makes human language special as opposed to other forms of animal communication?
- From a continuous, and often noisy, ambiguous or incomplete input, how do children learn the sounds, words, structures and meanings of their language, and how do adults understand what is said to them?

In exploring these questions, we will also review the core (e.g., experimental) methods that psycholinguists use to answer them. Important theoretical notions (e.g., phonemes, syntax trees, etc.) will be reviewed as we go along.

4. AI use

Please don't.

5. Prerequisites

Introduction to linguistics, as well as two linguistics courses (phonetics/phonology, morphology, syntax, or semantics).

6. Assessment

Your grade for this course is determined by:

- Participation 15%
- Midterm (in class) 35%
- Final (in class) 50%

7. Readings

All of the papers listed below are posted on Ilias. Some of them look difficult and are difficult, but they are often seminal papers on a given topic, and it is good to be confronted with this kind of difficulty and history. We will work through them together in order to become more literate on how good experiments are designed and their results, presented.

You may otherwise find it useful to read through the following textbook, which I'll post on Ilias. I won't directly ask you about its contents, but it's an easy introduction.

> Sedivy, Julie. 2019 (2nd edition). *Language in mind: An introduction to psycholinguistics*. Oxford University Press / Sinauer Associates.

8. Schedule

The schedule below *lists Mondays*—read it as 'the week in which you have class'. Information about holidays is indicated.

12/10 No class.

FINDING COMMON GROUND

19/10 What is language, what are psycholinguists, and how do they study it?

26/10 Situating human language within the landscape of other animal communication.

Readings (pick one)

von Frisch, Karl. (1973). Decoding the language of the bee.

Seyfarth, Robert et al. (1980). Vervet monkey alarm calls: Semantic communication in a free-ranging primate.

2/11 Monday 2/11 is a holiday; There is class on Tuesday 3/11.

We'll likely watch a documentary, at home for the Monday people and in class for the Tuesday people.

LANGUAGE ACQUISITION

9/11 Where even does a child begin? In utero.

Hoe is het mogelijk dat je iets kunt weten zonder het geleert te hebben?

Reading

Mehler, Jacaues et al. (1988). A precursor of language acquisition in young infants.

16/11 Gavagai!

Reading

Markman, Ellen. (1990). Constraints Children Place on Word Meanings.

ADULT PHONOLOGY

23/11 Background on phonetics and phonology. Categorical perception.

30/11 Categorical perception continued, focus on deciphering the reading.

Reading (for both weeks)

Liberman, Alvin et al. (1957). The discrimination of speech sounds within and across phoneme boundaries.

7/12 Spillover/midterm review

14/12 Midterm

21/12 Christmas special

ADULT SYNTAX

11/1 Background on syntax

18/1 The Parser

Readings (for both weeks, pick one)

Frazier, Lyn & Janet Fodor. 1978. The sausage machine: A new two-stage parsing model.

Bock, Kathryn. (1995). Producing agreement.

SEMANTICS & PRAGMATICS

25/1 Scalar implicature

Readings (pick one)

Bott, Lewis & Ira Noveck. (2004). Some utterances are underinformative: The onset and time course of scalar inferences.

Noveck, Ira. (2001). When children are more logical than adults: experimental investigations of scalar implicature.

1/2 Final

8/2 End of the semester special